

OPINION

2020 is the year our democracy died

In 2021, let's leave our echo chambers, share a reality and have an honest discussion



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I fear that 2020 will be remembered not for a historic pandemic, but as the year our democracy died.

It is true that many Americans are joyously celebrating Joe Biden's victory, the record 81 million votes he received, and the more than 50 court decisions repudiating election-fraud accusations. Yet it is plain that our country remains deeply divided.

Almost as many Americans (74 million) are literally distraught that Trump will not remain in the White House for another four years. Disturbingly, [polls show](#) 75 percent of these voters still refuse to acknowledge that he actually lost the election — despite the complete lack of verifiable evidence to support his groundless claims of victory.

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Each day, the chasm separating Americans is deepened by a flood of uncivil tweets, seditious Facebook posts and partisan cable news networks that sow division for profit, immediate attention or the simple hatred of those seen as different. Tragically, the turbulence leading up to, and continuing through, the recent presidential election has left many of us unable to conduct civil conversations with neighbors who do not share our political views.

Everyday citizens now fall all too readily into the trap of demonizing those who don't share a particular belief. Regardless of which side of the divide you stand upon, well-meaning folks of opposing views are too often labeled as iniquitous, unjust and malevolent — rather than misguided or misinformed. This dangerous — and now commonplace — practice gets reinforced and amplified by cable news programs and social networks.

Ordinary people have increasingly lost touch with reality because “alternative facts” are now almost indistinguishable from truth. In our present news ecosystem, it is almost impossible to establish the basic facts that both sides need as a prerequisite for any type of intelligent discussion of our real differences and the potential solutions to our common problems.

Most disturbing, many “leaders” of our country seem to think that truth counts for nothing at all. Indeed, this ongoing ideological warfare led 126 House Republicans and 17 state attorneys general to sign a spurious and disingenuous lawsuit to overturn the election results. Although the lawsuit was given short shrift by a unanimous Supreme Court (containing three Trump appointees), this judicial rebuke was largely ignored by the president, his supporters in Congress and numerous elected officials across the country.

To further their own agenda, these politicians preferred to breathe life into the treacherous myth that the election was compromised by massive voter fraud. In doing so, they stoked the fire of division by misleading tens of millions of Americans into buying this dangerous and undemocratic delusion.

Without question, there are legitimate grievances between and among both Republicans and Democrats. The problems of economic and social decay in small towns and rural communities are very real and must be addressed by our elected officials. It is equally true, though, that communities of color still face systematic racism and nationwide disenfranchisement schemes aimed at suppressing their votes. Nevertheless, if our democracy is to persist, we must set aside culture wars, find common ground as Americans and put aside differences in race, religion, region, gender, education and community.

I am an optimist by nature. I hope that the tragic consequences of the pandemic will serve as the genesis for a restored faith in science, not as an opportunity to further partisan divisions. But I fear the worst if the media, social networks and our politicians continue to obfuscate and conceal the truth. Unless Americans find some way to agree on the facts, we will never agree on the path forward.

I'll keep my fingers crossed that 2021 augurs the birth of a more honest discussion.

For this to occur, we must all try to escape from the echo chambers in which we too often find ourselves trapped. Only if we can agree upon a shared reality can we address the vital challenges that must be overcome if America is to continue as a beacon of democracy and a role model for the planet. If we choose to embrace alternative facts to justify our beliefs, our democracy has a scant chance of surviving the next decade.

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